LEARNING RITUAL

- *Learning ritual and delivering it well makes a big difference to our enjoyment of Freemasonry* and our meetings.
- *Not everyone wishes to learn ritual.* As a minimum, we ask new members to learn the questions and answers leading from one degree to another.
- *If a member does not wish to learn anything more than these, they can still be a member*, make a useful contribution to the Lodge and gain a lot of satisfaction and personal growth by doing so.
- *Few people are practised in rote learning today*, compared with earlier generations.
- Therefore, *new members will need plenty of advance notice, guidance and personal support*.
- Despite some claims that, "*Younger Freemasons won't learn ritual*", many Lodges have found that, *providing advance notice and assistance is offered, many younger, working Freemasons, enjoy the challenge and satisfaction that comes from learning and delivering ritual*.
- There are several books on learning techniques now available, but new members may find the following guidance helpful:
    - *Start learning three to six months before you are expected to deliver the ritual.*
    - *Allocate time each day to learning and use "committed time"; opportunities when you are doing something else but can attend to sound (eg, when travelling).*
    - *Start by reading the text over and over, initially silently "in your head."*
    - *Research words you don't understand and ask your Personal Mentor for clarification.*
    - *Continue by reading the words out loud, again over and over.*
    - *Then ask your personal mentor to check your phrasing, or use of punctuation, and pronunciation.*
    - *When you know you are expressing the words and their sentences correctly, record yourself or another member reading the ritual.*
    - *Play this recording repeatedly each day.*
    - *As you become more familiar with the words and their sound, test your ability to repeat passages by saying them out loud without reading the book or listening to the recording.*
    - *Begin by saying one sentence out loud and when you have learned that, add another, and then another.*
    - *Gradually increase the length of the passage you recite from memory.*
    - *Once you are at this stage, you could ask someone else to hold the book for you as you recite the passages.*
    - *Ask them not to interrupt you but to let you know where you went wrong when you had finished.*
    - *Note: if you ask someone who is not a Freemason to help in this way, be careful not to disclose to them any of the secrets covered by your obligations (ie, signs, tokens and words).*
    - *Repeat this until you can recite the whole passage.*
    - *Practice delivering your ritual in your Lodge meeting room (or other large space) with only one other person, such as your Personal Mentor or Lodge Preceptor, present.*
    - *Attend a Lodge of Instruction to deliver the piece to a group in a helpful environment.*